THE IMPACT OF CAVALRY IN THE EXPANSION OF THE RASHIDUN CALIPHATE

To what extent did cavalry techniques and technologies impacted the expansion of the Rashidun Caliphate?

by

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Introduction

In 680, John Bar Penkaye was recounting world history when he noted the rise of Islam and how “naked men, riding without armor or shield have been able to win” (Kennedy 1). While he assumed the reason for these conquests were up to God’s will, later historians had more investigations on what caused the sudden rise of the Arabs. To many contemporary scholars, early Muslim sources could not exactly pinpoint what allowed Islam to spread so fast. “Modern authors have tended to approach these in two ways: either to dismiss [the sources] as hopelessly inaccurate… or to cherry-pick them”(Kennedy 5). This essay seeks to prove that cavalry techniques and technologies greatly impacted the expansion of the Rashidun Caliphate. It will delve into the techniques used against the Sassanians and Byzantines and analyze the technologies cavalry used. This research is worthy of investigation because the rise of Islam changed the cultural landscape of the world and ended the Hellenistic/Persian influence of the Middle East - replacing it with an Arabized Islam that affected the economies and history of the rest of the world today. Cavalry from this time also was implemented in subsequent Islamic armies and set a standard for rapid conquest.

Against the Sassanids

Cavalry techniques to a great extent impacted expansion into the Sassanid Empire. Sassanian Iraq was on the frontier of the Arabian Peninsula inhabited by both Arabs and Persians. Its port city of Uballa was an economic center for the Sassanians (Akram 143). Prior to the invasion. Muslim leader Muthanna led a conquest into Iraq and saw the weaknesses of the country (Al-Mubarak 71). The Persian army was slow and vulnerable to attacks on their flanks, rear, and unexpected night attacks (Kennedy

101). In short, the Persian were not prepared for a Muslim invasion. In 633, Abu Bakr instructed Khalid to capture Hira, the capital of the Lakhmid kingdom (Akram 137). Khalid's force was a mobile army that didn't rely on supply trains and had the desert behind it.

The Iraqi campaign was prominently impacted by Rashidun cavalry techniques. Khalid used his cavalry to move along the Iraqi frontier while the Persian army gave chase. He went from Nibbaj, to Hufair, to Kazima (Akram 146). The constant movement exemplified Khalid's strategy to exhaust a slow Persian army whose fatigue gave the Arabs victory in the Battle of Chains. The victory left Uballa undefended and allowed Khalid to pass into Central Iraq. In Iraq, Rashidun forces used cavalry during key battles to create a swift victory. During the Battle of Walaja, Khalid moved 2,000 cavalry behind the Persian camp. The next day, he lured the Persian army of 25,000 to a frontal battle, causing them to leave their rear exposed. Then, the cavalry emerged from the rear and hit both flanks of the Persian army. This collapsed the Persian line as it cut their area of escape and left them vulnerable on all sides (Akram 158). The battle demonstrates how cavalry forces were able to defeat a larger force of Persians by attacking the rear. This technique brought a swift victory for the Caliphate and allowed Hira to be captured. The Persian capital fell shortly after. After 633, most of Iraq was subjugated with a sole garrison at Firaz. A coalition of Byzantine and Sassanid forces were defeated when Khalid moved his cavalry to the enemy flanks and attacked in a pincer movement - quickly defeating the force (Akram 187). This again demonstrates the impact of cavalry techniques on Rashidun expansion. Not only was the cavalry able to cement a victory, they helped establish Muslim rule in Iraq while Khalid moved to assist the Syrian

campaign. Rashidun forces also utilized cavalry for night attacks. After the conquest of Hira and establishing administration of central Iraq, Sassanid forces started congregating north of Hira at Muzayyanah (Akram 182). To eliminate any threat from these forces and to not go through many battles via the main route to the city, Khalid split his cavalry into 3 groups and ambushed the Sassanians at night - destroying half of the Sassanian's Arab Christian army. The cavalry technique of a swift night attack brought a quick victory to the Rashiduns without a direct confrontation with the Persians (al-Tabari 11: 62). Furthermore, because Persians were not adept at fighting night ambushes, the cavalry move was more deadly(Kennedy 101). The event allowed Western and Central Iraq to fall into Muslim hands. Because of situations at the Syrian front, Khalid was ordered to move out of Iraq to fight the Byzantines. Although Iraq lost its best cavalry commander, commander Al-Qa'qa and general Sa'ad covered this. Al-Qa'qa was an experienced cavalry commander and Khalid's right-hand man. He utilized Khalid's techniques to defeat and subdue Iraq. Using the Arab cavalry's ability to create holes in Persian lines, he was able kill the Persian commander, Rostman, at the battle of al-Qadisiyyah - contributing to the end of a 4-day stalemate between the Muslims and Persian counterattack (al-Tabari 12: 123). This demoralized the Persian army and allowed Sa'ad to route them to the river - bringing about the surrender of the forces captured (al-Tabari 12: 124). The event destroyed Sassanid resistance in most of Iraq. However, a Persian garrison at Jalula still posed a threat to the Muslim invaders. Qa'qa used a similar technique Kalhid used during the battle of Walaja and Firaz to destroy the Persians. After the Muslims drew the Sassanids out of the fort of Jalula, Qa'qa's cavalry unit secured the bridge otherwise allowing the Sassanians to escape.

Then, he attacked the Persian rear - surprising them and shattering the line (Kennedy 123). The Persian defeat conveys the impact of cavalry in the conquest of Iraq - with or without Khalid. After Jalula, all of Iraq was in Muslim hands. Cavalry techniques prominently impacted the conquest of Iraq.

Other than occasional skirmishes and raids such as al-Hadrami's raid into Fars province (south Iran), the Iranian front remained stable. But, the war in Iran proved the effectiveness of cavalry. Cavalry attacks here were used as shock and flank attacks to cripple Persian armies - ensuring a swift victory. This is evident in the battle of Nahavand. After the battle of Jalula and the conquest of Iraq, Yazdegard II started assembling a grand army in the country-town of Nahavand. The Persians held a strong defensive perimeter that repelled cavalry attacks while keeping the high ground - allowing them to repel any Muslim wave sent at them. To break this stalemate, the Muslim general Nu'man sent a cavalry force to hide while the main army retreated (al-Tabari 13: 181). When the Persians drew from their defenses to engage the main army, the cavalry force swiftly attacked the rear - crushing the Persian army in a Cannae movement similar to the battle of Walaja. The battle shows the effectiveness of cavalry by encircling the Persian army and crushing it in hours (Kennedy 172). Furthermore, it marked the decline of Sassania certainly - the regime was in collapse and local rulers defected at the opportunity. Thus, the conquest in rural and mountainous regions of Iran was more diplomatic as Muslim armies weren't able to effectively penetrate those areas. The majority of settlements accepted Muslim rule and agreed to pay the jizya tax (Kennedy 173). However in the south, there was still more Persian resistance. The capital, Istakhr, held in siege before surrendering and after sallying out to face the

invaders (al-Tabari 14: 67). Sirjan, the capital of Kirman, also fell without much fight. Same occurred in Sistan province where most towns surrendered peacefully with the capital putting up little resistance before surrendering (Kennedy 187) (al-Tabari 14: 75). Muslim sources for these stages of the conquest, however, focus on the terms of conquest rather than the resistance encountered. This is portrayed by al-Tabari's accounts and Kennedy's vagueness in the conquest of these regions. With the Muslim army now entering Khorasan province, the king, Yazdegard III, who had been in pursuit by the Arabs, met his end by a local miller. The capital of the province, Khorasan, peacefully accepted Arab occupation (Kennedy 191). Local towns and leaders accepted Muslim occupation and infighting between Iranian families contributed to further decline. For example, the fall of the town of Rayy, near modern Tehran, fell when a rival Persian family allowed the Muslims inside the city - deposing the old family and claiming governorship (Kennedy 177). Similarly, the regions of Tabaristan and Gilan, remote areas in the Sasanian Empire, were "conquered" in negotiation - paying less taxes than during Sassanid rule.

Cavalry techniques greatly impacted the conquest of the Sassanid Empire. It allowed the Arabs to destroy Persian garrisons/armies in a fractured empire.

Against the Byzantines and Africans

Cavalry techniques greatly impacted expansion into Byzantine controlled regions such as North Africa, Egypt, and Syria. The *Strategikon of Maurice* details the military of the Byzantine Empire during the reign of Emperor Maurice, a man who ruled as emperor of the Byzantine Empire from 582 to 602 (Kennedy 101). In it, he showed that the Empire had a weakness in cavalry forces that limited the maneuvers it could do on

the battlefield while also supporting the flanks of an army's wings(Dennis and Maurice 23). The heavy cavalry was used in charges on enemy lines. It was noted that long lines for armies inevitably crossed into rough terrain and bring disorder to the cavalry units (Dennis and Maurice 23) Calvary and infantry were also intertwined in their areas of formation. If the enemy had more cavalry, the infantry would not fight in open battle because of the ability for enemy rear/flank attacks (Dennis and Maurice 167). In 634, Khalid and his forces moved into Syria, attacking Ghassanid forces and joined other Muslim commanders in the area. Once joined, the Muslim army attacked and besieged Bostra, a city in southern Syria. They then met with a Byzantine force at Ajnadayn in Palestine. Not much is known from this battle except that the Byzantines lost and retreated to Jerusalem. Soon, the Muslims besieged Damascus, which fell within a month from lack of resources. Heraclius, the Byzantine Emperor (Kennedy 82), planned for a counter-offensive in the Levant to offset the defeats that had occurred. In late 635, Heraclius marched a 15,000-20,000 strong army (Kennedy 82) to meet the Muslims on the plains of Yarmuk, an area surrounded by cliffs and rolling hills that still allowed for cavalry maneuvers. During the battle, Khalid and his Mobile Guard sent a regiment to hold the Byzantine cavalry to ensure that it didn't support the Slavs and Armenians - whose lines were fracturing from lack of support (Akram 281). Then, Khalid, along with Amr (another Muslim commander in the battle) attacked the flanks of the Byzantine front and rear (Akram 282). The Byzantine line cracked as an assault from Abu Ubaidah, the leading commander of the Levant, attacked the center while Khalid pressed into the flanks. Realizing the situation, the Byzantine army broke contact and retreated north. Thus, the Battle of Yarmuk ended in a Muslim victory. Victory was achieved from the

exploitation of cavalry-infantry independence. The *Strategikon* states that interdependence can be fatal when cavalry is separate and the enemy has cavalry in an area that is maneuverable. Furthermore, the ferocity of the attack from Khalid was brought from the cavalry's lack of maneuvering while supporting the left-wing (Akram 281). The Muslims were able to exploit this with their own cavalry. Yarmuk was the final blow to Byzantine resistance in the Levant as Muslims were the dominant force. Thus, cavalry significantly impacted the expansion of the Rashidun Caliphate with cavalry techniques. Following the battle, the Arab army "reduced the cities of Syria to obedience"(Kennedy 85). Although some city garrisons remained intact, a lack of reinforcements eventually led to surrenders/sacking. After the Syrian/Palestinian conquest and the capture of Gaza(Kennedy 146), the Muslims looked west towards Egypt.

Amr ibn al-As and his army of 3500-4000 men crossed into eastern Egypt with the goal of taking Babylon (Kennedy 149). This was a small army that couldn't take on the fortified cities of Egypt by itself and was prompted to raid towns without a strong garrison. However, Abu's army received reinforcements from Zubayr b. al-Awwam, an early Companion of the Prophet, with 12,000 men. Abu was largely unopposed during his merge with the Companion - something the Byzantines could have used to advantage to destroy Abu before uniting with Zubayr (Kennedy 150). Realizing that the Heliopsis garrison could attack the Arabs, Abu decided to camp outside the ancient city to draw out the Byzantine garrison - which he succeeded in doing. The Byzantine commander of Egypt, Theodore, advanced to Abu's position and engaged him in 640 on the flat plains outside modern Cairo (Kennedy 151). While Abu used his main army to

take on the Byzantines, he used a smaller regiment of cavalry to attack weak flanks in the Byzantine line. Theodore didn't send scouts or any form of reconnaissance (Butler 221-237). So when the cavalry did attack, the Byzantines panicked and broke - allowing the Arabs to easily win. The engagement eliminated a big threat to Arab operations within Egypt. Zubayr's battle-hardened, Syrian veterans used moves similar to that in the Battle of Yarmouk to cripple the Byzantine line and achieve a quick victory without losses - allowing them to expand without additional reinforcements. The defeat at Heliopolis prompted the governor of Fayoum to run - allowing the Arabs to easily occupy the city. Furthermore , without the presence of Byzantine reinforcements, a success at the siege of Babylon would be inevitable - which occurred in 641 when infiltrators opened the gates of Babylon to the Muslim army (Kennedy 153). With the defense of Egypt eliminated, reinforcements to the capital, Alexandria, from land were unfeasible. However, Alexandria's defenses were capable of withstanding a siege against the invaders. The siege played out for 6 months before the city surrendered after the death of emperor Heraclius. This contributed to local Copts realizing the futility of resisting and allowed them to break from the Byzantines - whose taxes were much harsher. In al-Tabari's account, the patriarch of Alexandria agreed to pay the jizya as he deemed it less atrocious than that of the Byzantine tax (al-Tabari 13: 164) The Coptic patriarch held terms with the Arabs and peacefully surrendered the city. Alexandria was spared from sacking but its capture ended Byzantine rule in Egypt (Kennedy 159). Cavalry shock and rear attacks greatly impacted Rashidun expansion by eliminating Byzantine resistance in the open country - enabling the surrender of Egyptian cities.

Contrary to Egypt, the Nubian invasion ended in failure. Nubian guerilla fighters wounded cavalry forces as they marched to the Nubian capital, Dongala. When the Muslim army arrived at Dongala, they were repelled by Nubian archers who could shoot at pinpoint accuracy (al-Tabari 13: 175). The failed invasion of Nubia depicts one of the weaknesses of Rashidun cavalry - their vulnerability to arrowfire. This was demonstrated at the Battle of Yarmouk where Byzantine forces pushed back Arab advances with their superior arrow fire as Arab bows had a shorter range (Akram 211).

However, the cavalry techniques had a greater impact on the conquest of the Maghreb. After the conquest of Egypt, Amr was able to capture cities along the North African coast with ease because of their lack of defenses. His army conquered Tripoli through siege and Sabratha using a shock cavalry force to keep the city's gates open for the main army to attack (Kennedy 207). But, the caliph requested him back to Egypt. In 647, the new governor of Egypt, Abdullah assembled another invasion after analyzing the riches of the Maghreb - now under control of the Exarchate of Africa, the independent Byzantine North Africa. Abdullah moved to recapture Tripoli but went to attack the Exarchate capital at Sufetula after reports the Exarch, Gregory, was preparing for a fight (al-Tabari 15: 19). The two armies met at Sufetula's front, on a plain carved by two, bordering ridges - though impossible to cross. The battle was drawing to a stalemate until a defector informed the Muslims of a vulnerability in the city itself. Using this, the Muslims put their cavalry units on the ridge and had others raid the city while the main armies were fighting. Then, the cavalry attacked Gregory's troops at the rear while the main Rashidun army pushed at the front. This created an unwinnable situation that soon resulted in Gregory's death (al-Tabari 15: 19). After the battle, there

were no Exarch armies standing in the way (Kennedy 208), so Abdullah pushed to Carthage, which he left in exchange for a huge sum of money - ending Rashidun expansion in the Maghreb. Cavalry techniques greatly impacted Rashidun expansion in the Maghreb by using rear and shock attacks to destroy open-field armies that could pose a threat to excursions in North Africa. It also left fortified cities around the coast such as Carthage unable to remove the invaders - often negotiating for terms.

Rashidun Muslim armies greatly expanded the Islamic Caliphate using cavalry techniques. Cavalry attacks quickly destroyed/pushed Byzantine armies into an unwinnable fight in the countryside. This would remove barriers to attack and capture key cities in both Egypt and the Maghreb. However, the Rashidun army was unable to penetrate into sub-Saharan Africa because of the harsh terrain and superior weaponry of the Nubians. Furthermore, the demoralization of Byzantine forces significantly contributed to terms offered to the invaders. Here, the cavalry techniques greatly expanded the Caliphate but through the influence of many other factors.

The Arabian Arsenal

Mounts

Emerging out of the desert, the Arab utilized many technologies that helped it greatly expand when they swept across the Middle East. Rashidun technology greatly impacted expansion to the extent that the technology was adaptable and effective in an environment outside of Arabia. The horse is adept to the harshness of the deserts of the Arabian Peninsula from centuries of Bedouin breeding (Klimek).The Arabian horse has a facial structure that prevents airway blockage and allows for optimum oxygen intake - allowing the horse to run without experiencing shortness of breath and maintain a high endurance (Klimek). Furthermore, the Arabian horse has a top speed of 65

km/hr. Because of these qualities, the horse made the Bedouin Arab the master of the desert - able to travel in hot conditions to maintain links with the caliph in Medina and keep stable communication to aid in the conquests of the Middle East (Akram 146). This demonstrates the significance of the horse as a means of communication for the Caliph to oversee and command troops. The Arabian horse greatly impacted the expansion of the Rashidun Caliphate through its usage in many areas - serving as the most common breed of horses used during the Rashidun conquests (Schiettecatte and Zouache 51-59). The horse was used for both shock troops and Khalid's mobile guard in battles from Yarmouk to Walaja. During the North African campaign, Amr ibn al-As was able to cross the Maghreb fast (Kennedy 206). This was in large part due to the use of Arabian horses and its deployment in a relatively flat environment from Eastern Libya to modern-day Algiers ("North Africa"). The Arabian horse was adaptable outside of Arabia and effective in expanding the Caliphate. Another important technology was the Arabian Camel. The Arabian Camel weighs an average of 300 to 690 kg and stands 1.8 to 2.3 m ("Dromedary Camel"). This figure made the camel the "Arabian tank" - it could be used to transport goods and people on long distances while standing strong and resilient. This resilience was exemplified when Khalid marched into the Syrian desert to assist the Levant Campaign. The area crossed was virtually waterless, but the camel's resilience to dehydration and water storage helped Khalid's troops march into Syria (Akram 193). The feat conveys the usefulness of the Arabian Camel far from Arabia as well as its effectiveness. The use of the camel to cross the Syrian desert helped expand the Caliphate by ambushing Byzantine forces from an unexpected angle. The camel was associated as a "fierce" animal that "refused to budge" to threats (Kennedy 261).

This toughness was displayed during the Battle of Yarmouk where camel lines would blunt enemy cavalry charges. The Arabian camel was highly adaptable and effective in the early Muslim conquests - allowing the cavalry to greatly expand the Caliphate.

<u>Reflection</u>: The highlighting in the mounted technology paragraph is much better and includes a variety of commentary that links to the topic sentence. One thing that the highlighting showed me is that I still have a lot of implication commentary without linking how that evidence is meant to be implied as such. My example of Khalid's march should be effectively written with an analysis portion of commentary-not just evaluation that thats what may not be apparent.

Weaponry

Cavalry weaponry greatly impacted the expansion of the Caliphate but not to the extent of techniques. The Arabian curved sword was an effective weapon in battle. Rather than the possibility of getting the weapon stuck in the target, the curved sword could slice cleanly and at close range(Akram 4). This was useful in cavalry charges where soldiers could slice through enemies while going at a fast pace. It also allowed for speed because the Arabian curved sword didn't need more energy for thrusting into the enemy - using the momentum of the horse to slice into them. For example, during the siege of Damascus, Byzantine forces were cut down by Khalid's cavalry charge as they fled back to the city (Akram, 231). The weapon expanded territory by quickly cutting down enemy forces and offering Rashidun cavalry a deadly attack in rear/shock assaults. The lance also played a huge factor. The lance is a pointy, long shaft used by the Rashidun cavalry to break defensive lines during battles - able to do so because the reach and force it carried could knock out defensive fronts. These would allow armies to create holes in enemy lines and make them more susceptible to encirclement. Arab

lances were also lighter to maintain the advantage of speed for the Arabs (Kennedy, 59). In the battle of Walaja, the rear cavalry attack used lances to break the Persian line and win the battle (Akram, 159). Because of their importance in offensive techniques, lances greatly impacted Rashidun expansion.

<u>Reflection</u>: The highlighting here I think is the best. It shows that the paragraph is organized well and I have evidence effectively linking to the topic sentence. However, the highlighting showed me that I should sort my evidence to be before the commentary. That way, it would be less confusing to read. For example, I included Khalid's Damascus cavalry charge after I analyzed the effects of the Arabian sword in battle.

Cavalry technology greatly impacted the expansion of the caliphate. However, it had less of an impact on the techniques cavalry units used. The Arabs used less effective bows compared to the Sassasnids and Romans. But, they used a feigned retreat to attack enemies close-range (al-Tabari 13: 181) or shooting on many flanks in attacks. For the Arabs, the user determined the significance of the weapon.

Conclusion

The Iraqi campaign was prominently successful through cavalry techniques by destroying large, unprepared field armies. In Syria and Egypt, cavalry techniques destroyed potential reinforcements to fall large cities. In the Maghreb and Iran, however, cavalry techniques didn't impact expansion as much - instead sieges and diplomacy was used with cavalry contributing to the collapse of enemy administrative support. The failure of Nubia was through cavalry weaknesses to arrow fire as seen at Yarmuk. The

Arab mounts contributed to the success of cavalry techniques while weaponry depended more on the skill of the user than the power of the weapon. Cavalry techniques and technologies greatly impacted Rashidun expansion to the extent of removing support/field armies and contributing to further cracks in the targeted states. The Copt-Byzantine tension in Egypt allowed for the fall of Alexandria. The Irani campaign was largely successful through political and imperial instability. Iraq and Syria were the endgames of both empires - depleting imperial manpower and allowing for further conquest. However, it is not to say cavalry didn't make gains in these places as in all parts of the conquests as the sources indicate the importance of cavalry in delivering a swift victory. But, the sources have their limits. The Islamic records focus more on the implications of conquest and the fates of individuals rather than an overview of the conquests. Arab attacked territory already fractured by decay, infighting, and war.

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